Max & Mia Podcast — How to Argue Politely in English

Mia: Hi everyone and welcome back to another episode of Max & Mia Podcast. I'm Mia.

Max: And I'm Max. Really glad you're here with us today.

Mia: So, before we get into today's topic, we just wanted to take a second to say thank you. The response we've been getting lately has been a little overwhelming, in the best way possible.

Max: Exactly. We read your messages, we see your comments, and honestly, it means a lot to know that what we're doing here is actually useful to someone.

Mia: So thank you for that. And if you're new here — hey, welcome. You picked a good time to join.

Max: We hope you stick around. Alright, let's get into it.

Speaking Exercise

Mia: So Max, I was thinking the other day… you know what's funny? A lot of people who are learning English — and I mean people who are really putting in the effort — they can read, they can understand movies, they can even write pretty well… but the moment someone asks them to *speak*, it's like everything just disappears.

Max: Oh, completely. It's almost like a mental block, right? And the frustrating part is that it makes total sense why it happens. If you live in a country where English isn't the main language, when exactly are you supposed to practice? You're not having conversations in English at the supermarket, you're not calling your bank in English… it just doesn't come up naturally.

Mia: Exactly. And the thing is, people sometimes feel like if they're not in an English-speaking country, they can't really improve their speaking. But that's not true at all. You just have to be a little more creative about how you practice.

Max: Which is actually something we want to talk about more today. But before we get into the main topic, we thought — why not do a little speaking exercise right now? Because that's the whole point, isn't it? You have to actually open your mouth.

Mia: Right. So here's what we're going to do. We're going to put you in a situation. A real one. Something that could actually happen.

Max: Imagine this: you're at a stadium. Maybe it's a football match, maybe it's a concert, whatever you're into. You've got your ticket, you find your seat… and someone is already sitting in it.

Mia: And this happens more than you'd think, by the way.

Max: It really does. So the question is, what do you say to that person? Not in your native language, not in your head, out loud, in English.. Find a quiet place, somewhere you feel comfortable, and actually say it. Don't think too much, just go for it.

Mia: We'll give you a moment.

Max: Alright. So what would *we* say? Mia, you go first.

Mia: Okay, so I'd probably go with something like: *"Hey, sorry to bother you — I think you might be in my seat. Let me just double-check… yeah, I've got row C, seat 14. Do you have your ticket handy?"* Friendly, but clear.

Max: Yeah, I like that. I think I'd go a bit more direct, but still polite: *"Excuse me, I think there might be a mix-up — this is actually my seat. Could you check your ticket?"* Short, calm, no drama.

Mia: Both work. And notice that neither of us started with "YOU'RE IN MY SEAT, MOVE." — which, believe me, some people's instinct is to go straight there.

Max: Right. Okay, but now let's make it a little harder. Because in real life, things don't always go smoothly.

Mia: So — same situation. You've asked nicely, but the person refuses to move. They're not having it. You have to call security. And when security arrives, they're going to ask you a few questions.

Max: Same as before — find your quiet place, and answer out loud. Ready?

Mia: Here we go:

Question 1: *"Can you tell me what happened here?"*

Question 2: *"Do you have your ticket with you? Can I see it?"*

Question 3: *"And did you ask this person to move before calling us?"*

Max: Alright, let's hear how we'd handle those.

Mia: So for the first one — *"Can you tell me what happened here?"* — I'd say something like: *"Sure. I came to my seat and found this person already sitting here. I showed them my ticket and asked them politely to move, but they said the seat was theirs and refused to leave."* Clear, factual, no drama.

Max: For the ticket question, easy: *"Yes, here you go. You can see it's row C, seat 14 — same as the one they're sitting in."*

Mia: And for the last one — *"Did you ask them to move first?"* — I'd just say: *"Yes, I did. I tried to sort it out without getting anyone else involved, but it didn't work out."*

Max: Which honestly is such a key thing — in any conflict, showing that you tried to resolve it yourself first makes a big difference. It says a lot about you.

Mia: It really does. And you know what? That whole situation — asking someone to move, explaining yourself to security, staying calm under pressure — that's actually a perfect way into what we're talking about today.

Max: Because knowing how to handle a disagreement in English — politely, clearly, without losing your cool — is genuinely one of the most useful skills you can have. And a lot of learners just don't know how to do it.

Mia: So today, we're going to get into exactly that: **how to argue politely in English.**

How to Argue Politely in English

Max: So let's start with something basic. When most people have a disagreement in English, what's the first word that comes out?

Mia: "No."

Max: Exactly. Just "no." Or even worse — silence, because they don't know what to say. And look, there's nothing wrong with "no" — but in a real conversation, especially a tense one, just saying "no" can come across as rude, even if that's not your intention at all.

Mia: And that's the thing about English — tone and word choice matter a lot. You can say the exact same thing in two different ways and one sounds completely reasonable while the other sounds like you're starting a fight.

Max: So let's talk about some key phrases. Things you can actually use.

Mia: Right. So first — instead of just saying "no, you're wrong" — which, again, sounds pretty aggressive — you can say something like: *"I see where you're coming from, but…"* or *"I understand your point, however…"*

Max: Those two little phrases do a lot of work. They show you actually listened to the other person before responding. And that goes a long way.

Mia: Another one that's really useful: *"With all due respect…"* — now, be careful with this one. In English, this phrase is a way of softening something you're about to say that might be uncomfortable. But if you say it the wrong way, it can actually sound sarcastic.

Max: Yeah, tone is everything with that one.

Mia: So practice it. Say it calmly, not dramatically. *"With all due respect, I don't think that's quite accurate."*

Max: Now let's talk about something that a lot of learners struggle with — and this is more of a grammar point. When you're disagreeing, there's a big difference between saying *"You are wrong"* and *"I think there might be a misunderstanding."*

Mia: Huge difference.

Max: The first one puts the blame directly on the other person. The second one opens a door — it suggests maybe neither of you has the full picture. And in English, especially in professional or formal situations, that kind of language — what we call "hedging" — is really important.

Mia: Hedging. Good word. So hedging means softening your statements so they don't sound too absolute. Instead of *"This is wrong"* you say *"I'm not sure this is entirely correct."* Instead of *"You didn't understand me"* you say *"I think I might not have explained myself clearly enough."*

Max: And that last one is actually a great trick — turning it back on yourself, even when you're right. It defuses tension immediately.

Mia: Now, let's talk about vocabulary for a second — because this is something that really separates a good English speaker from a great one. A lot of learners get stuck using the same words over and over. "Bad", "good", "big problem", "I don't agree"…

Max: Which are fine, but they don't really paint a picture.

Mia: Exactly. So let's upgrade some of those. Instead of *"That's a big problem"* — try *"That's a significant issue"* or *"That raises a serious concern."* Instead of *"I don't agree"* — try *"I beg to differ"* or *"I'm not entirely convinced by that."*

Max: And instead of *"That's wrong"* — you could say *"I think that might be a misconception"* or *"That doesn't quite hold up."*

Mia: See how much more natural and composed that sounds? You're saying the same thing, but the way you say it makes you sound calmer, more confident, more in control of the situation.

Max: Which brings us to probably the most common mistake — and it's not really a grammar mistake, it's more of a habit. People tend to over-explain when they're nervous. They start a sentence, then go back, then add more, then apologize mid-sentence…

Mia: *"Sorry, I mean, what I wanted to say is, well, it's not that I disagree completely, I just…"*

Max: And by the time you've finished, you've kind of lost the argument just from the way you said it.

Mia: So the tip here is: short, clear sentences. State your point. Let it land. You don't need to fill every silence.

Max: Alright — I think the best way to put all of this into practice is to actually hear it in a real conversation. So we've put together an audio for you — a dialogue between two people in a natural situation where this kind of polite arguing comes up.

Mia: Listen carefully — not just to *what* they say, but *how* they say it. The phrases they use, the way they pause, the tone. That's where a lot of the learning happens.

Max: Here's Audio Number One.

AUDIO #1

(A customer approaches the manager of a restaurant after a deeply unsatisfactory experience.)

Customer: Excuse me, are you the manager on duty?

Manager: Yes, that's me. Is everything alright?

Customer: Not quite, no. I was hoping to have a word with you, if that's okay. I've just had quite a disappointing experience here and I feel it's worth bringing to your attention.

Manager: Of course. I'm sorry to hear that. Please, go ahead.

Customer: Thank you. So, first of all, the wait time. We were seated at around eight o'clock and didn't receive our food until nearly nine thirty. At no point did anyone come to our table to explain the delay or even acknowledge it. We had to ask twice just to find out what was going on, and both times the response we got was, frankly, dismissive.

Manager: I sincerely apologize for that. That is not the standard we hold ourselves to and I completely understand your frustration.

Customer: I appreciate you saying that. And I want to be fair — I understand that restaurants get busy. That's not lost on me. But there's a difference between being busy and making your customers feel like an inconvenience. And that's honestly how we felt tonight.

Manager: You're absolutely right, and I'm not going to make excuses for that.

Customer: I'd also like to mention something that was a bit more uncomfortable to bring up. At one point during the evening, I noticed that a table which arrived after us — and I'm being quite specific here — was attended to almost immediately. Their drinks came quickly, their food came quickly, and the staff seemed noticeably more attentive toward them. I don't want to make assumptions, but the contrast was hard to ignore, and it left us feeling, well… unwelcome. Like we weren't quite the right kind of customer for this place.

Manager: I hear you, and I want you to know that I'm taking that very seriously. That kind of disparity in service should never happen, and if there was any bias — whether intentional or not — it is something I will be looking into directly with my team.

Customer: I'm glad to hear that. Look, I'm not here to cause trouble or demand anything unreasonable. I just think that if you're going to run a place like this, people deserve to be treated with the same level of respect regardless of who they are or what they look like. That should be the baseline.

Manager: You are completely right, and I am genuinely grateful that you came to speak with me rather than simply walking out. It takes a certain kind of patience to do that, and I don't take it lightly. I'd like to offer you a full refund for this evening, and I'd personally like to invite you back so we can show you what this restaurant is actually capable of.

Customer: I appreciate that. And I do hope things improve — not just for us, but for everyone who comes through that door.

Manager: That's the goal. Thank you for being so straightforward with me. I mean that.

Commentary on Audio #1

Mia: Okay, so — what did you pick up on?

Max: Honestly, a lot. But the first thing I want to highlight is how the customer handled the discrimination part. Because that's tricky territory. It's emotional, it's uncomfortable, and it's very easy to either go too strong and sound accusatory, or hold back too much and not really say what you mean.

Mia: Right. And what she did was he framed it as an observation — *"the contrast was hard to ignore"* — rather than a direct accusation. She didn't say *"you treated us differently because of how we look."* She described what he saw and let the manager draw the conclusion.

Max: Which is actually more powerful. Because now the manager can't get defensive about being accused of something — instead, he has to respond to a fact. And that's a really mature way to handle that kind of situation.

Mia: The other thing I loved was this line: *"I understand that restaurants get busy. That's not lost on me."* Because he's essentially saying — I'm not unreasonable, I get it. And that immediately makes everything else she says more credible.

Max: Exactly. You're not coming in as someone who just wants to complain — you're coming in as someone who has a legitimate point. There's a difference.

Mia: And the manager — notice how he never once made an excuse. He said *"I'm not going to make excuses for that."* That phrase alone probably stopped the situation from escalating.

Max: It's disarming. Because when someone is ready to argue and the other person just… agrees with them, there's nowhere for the tension to go.

Mia: So the takeaway here is: when you're in a difficult conversation, be specific, stay calm, and give the other person room to respond without feeling attacked. That's how you get results.

Max: Alright, let's shift gears a little. Because not every difficult conversation happens in a restaurant with a manager. Some of them happen on the sofa, after a long day, with someone you trust.

Mia: Oh, we've all been there.

Max: You come home, you're exhausted, you're frustrated, and you just need to… let it out. And that's actually a really important skill in English — knowing how to express that kind of emotional weight. Not in a formal way, but in a natural, human way.

Mia: And there are a few expressions that come up a lot in these moments. *"I just need to vent"* — meaning, I need to talk about this, I'm not necessarily looking for advice, I just need to say it out loud.

Max: Or *"I need to get this off my chest"* — which means there's something that's been weighing on you and you need to release it.

Mia: And *"let it out"* — which is more general, but it captures that feeling of finally being able to say what you've been holding in all day.

Max: These expressions are really common in everyday English and they signal to the other person: hey, I'm not okay right now, just listen. And knowing how to use them — or how to respond when someone says them to you — makes a big difference.

Mia: So in our next audio, we're going to see exactly that. Two people, one of them has had a rough day at work, and what follows is one of the most relatable conversations you'll hear. Let's get into it.

Max: Here's Audio Number Two.

AUDIO #2

(Julia arrives home after a long day at work. Peter is in the kitchen.)

Julia: *(sighs) Hi honey,* I'm home.

Peter: Hey, you're later than usual. Everything okay?

Julia: Not really, no. I just… I need to vent. Is that okay? I just need to get this off my chest before I explode.

Peter: Of course. Come sit down. What happened?

Julia: Okay, so you know how I've been putting in extra hours these past few weeks to finish the Henderson account? Like, staying late, skipping lunch, the whole thing?

Peter: Yeah, I noticed. You've been coming home completely worn out.

Julia: Right. So today we had the quarterly review meeting — the big one — and Marcus presented the results. And I'm sitting there thinking, okay, this is the moment. And he goes through the whole thing, takes all the credit, and at no point — not once — does he mention that half of that work was mine.

Peter: Are you serious?

Julia: Dead serious. And the worst part? Our director was right there. She saw the whole presentation. And Marcus just stood up there like he had done everything on his own. I felt completely invisible.

Peter: That's not okay, Julia. That's really not okay.

Julia: I know! And I tried to brush it off, I really did. But then after the meeting, a colleague came up to me and said "great job on the report" — to me, not to Marcus — and I just… I almost broke down right there.

Peter: Because you knew the recognition should have come from him, not from a colleague in the hallway.

Julia: Exactly. And look, I don't need a round of applause for everything I do. But this has been building up for months. He always does this. He takes what I put together, tidies it up a little, puts his name on it, and moves on. And every time I bring it up, he brushes me off and says we're a team and that's how it works.

Peter: That's such a convenient thing to say when you're the one benefiting from it.

Julia: That's exactly what it is. And I'm so fed up. I've been holding this in all day and I just — I can't keep letting it go. At some point I need to actually say something.

Peter: I think you're right. And I think you know that too, or it wouldn't be eating at you like this.

Julia: It's just… confrontation at work is so uncomfortable. What if it makes things awkward? What if he turns it around on me?

Peter: Those are fair concerns. But think about it this way — right now you're already uncomfortable. You're already frustrated. The only difference is that you're carrying it alone. At least if you speak up, there's a chance things actually change.

Julia: Yeah. Yeah, you're right. I think I just needed to hear someone say it out loud.

Peter: So what are you going to do?

Julia: I'm going to sleep on it tonight. And tomorrow I'm going to ask Marcus for a one-on-one and I'm going to be very clear about how I feel and what I expect going forward.

Peter: That sounds like a plan. And for what it's worth — I see how hard you work. Even if he doesn't.

Julia: Thank you. That actually helps more than you know.

Commentary on Audio #2

Mia: Okay. That one hit a little close to home.

Max: Yeah, I think a lot of people are going to recognise themselves in that conversation — either as Julia or as Peter.

Mia: Let's start with something small but important. Right at the beginning, Julia says: *"I need to vent. Is that okay?"* And that little question — "is that okay?" — does something really specific. It tells Peter: I'm not looking for you to fix anything, I just need you to listen.

Max: And Peter picks up on that immediately. He doesn't jump in with solutions. He doesn't say "well, have you tried talking to HR?" He just says *"come sit down, what happened?"* — which is exactly the right response.

Mia: That's actually a really useful thing to keep in mind, both in English and in general. When someone says they need to vent, your job is to be present, not to problem-solve. At least not straight away.

Max: Now, let's talk about some of the expressions Julia uses. *"I've been putting in extra hours"* — that's a natural way to say you've been working more than usual. You could also say *"I've been putting in a lot of work"* or *"I've really been going above and beyond lately."*

Mia: Then there's *"he takes all the credit"* — meaning he receives the recognition for something he didn't fully do. The opposite would be *"to give credit where it's due"* — which is something Marcus clearly didn't do.

Max: And one that I think is really worth keeping — *"this has been building up for months."* That phrase captures something really specific: not a single bad day, but a frustration that has been growing slowly over time. It's much more expressive than just saying "I've been frustrated for a long time."

Mia: Peter also has a great line: *"you're already carrying it alone."* That's a very natural, human way of putting it. Not clinical, not dramatic — just honest.

Max: And then Julia wraps it up with *"I'm going to sleep on it"* — meaning she's not going to make a decision right now, she's going to take the night to think it over. Really common expression, very useful.

Mia: The big takeaway from this conversation is that expressing frustration in English doesn't have to mean raising your voice or losing control. You can be completely open about how you feel and still sound composed. That's actually one of the hardest things to pull off in a second language — and it comes with practice.

Max: Which brings us to something we say every episode and we genuinely mean: the only way to get better at speaking is to actually speak. Not just listen to us, not just read transcripts — open your mouth, use these phrases, make them yours.

Mia: Try it out loud right now if you want. Pretend you're Julia. Tell someone — your wall, your mirror, your cat — about a frustrating day at work. Use *"I need to vent,"* use *"this has been building up,"* use *"I'm so fed up."* It doesn't matter if it's perfect. What matters is that you do it.

Max: That's honestly where the progress happens. Not in the listening — in the doing.

Mia: Alright, that's it for today's episode. If you made it this far, thank you — genuinely. It means a lot that you stick around to the end.

Max: If today's episode was useful to you, it would really help us out if you left a like and subscribed. It's a small thing on your end, but it makes a real difference for us.

Mia: And we'll be back soon with more. Until then — keep practicing, keep speaking, and don't be too hard on yourself. You're doing better than you think.

Max: Take care, everyone.

Mia: See you next time.